

Piano Chord Roadmap

Twelve stages from “where is C?” to reading lead sheets with 7th and 9th chords. Each stage tells you what to understand, practise, memorise and ignore, and how it leads to the next. You play songs from Stage 3 onwards.

■ root note ■ other chord notes **C** major **Am** minor **Bdim** diminished

The route

Four phases. Time spans are a rough guide for about 30 minutes of practice a day. Move on when you pass the checkpoint, not when the calendar says so.

PHASE A · ROUGH GUIDE: WEEKS 1–3

Foundations

- 1 The keyboard and the 12 notes
- 2 Major and minor chords

PHASE B · WEEKS 4–8

Playing with chords

- 3 Your first progressions and songs
- 4 Inversions

PHASE C · MONTHS 3–5

Understanding keys

- 5 The major scale and scale degrees
- 6 Diatonic chords and Roman numerals
- 7 Common chord progressions
- 8 The Circle of Fifths and all 12 keys
- 9 Minor keys

PHASE D · MONTH 6 ONWARDS

Richer harmony

- 10 More chord symbols: sus, add9, 6, slash chords
- 11 Seventh chords
- 12 Extended chords and voicings

Recommended order

Your list was a good skeleton. I changed five things so you play music earlier and learn each concept when you actually need it.

Your no.	Your order	Recommended	Change	Why
1	Notes and the keyboard	1. Keyboard and 12 notes	SAME	Same start. Half steps come in here, because chords are built from them.
2	Major scales	5. Major scale	LATER	Moved later. You can build chords by counting half steps, so you play real music sooner.
3–4	Major chords, minor chords	2. Major and minor chords	EARLIER	Merged and moved first. Major and minor differ by one note, so learn them side by side.
–	(not in your list)	3. First progressions and songs	NEW	Added early. Playing songs from week 4 keeps motivation high and shows you why theory matters.
10	Inversions	4. Inversions	EARLIER	Moved from 10 to 4. Without inversions every chord change is a jump. With them your songs sound smooth right away.
7–8	Diatonic chords, Roman numerals	6. Diatonic chords and numerals	SAME	Merged. Numerals are just names for the diatonic chords, so learn them together.
9	Common progressions	7. Common progressions	SAME	
5–6	The 12 keys, Circle of Fifths	8. Circle of Fifths and all 12 keys	LATER	Merged and moved after progressions. The circle makes sense once you know what I, IV and V are. Then you learn keys gradually in circle order.
–	(not in your list)	9. Minor keys	NEW	Added. Many songs are in minor. The relative minor sits on the circle's inner ring.
–	(not in your list)	10. sus, add9, 6, slash chords	NEW	Added before 7ths. These symbols are common in pop charts and easier than 7th chords.
11	Seventh chords	11. Seventh chords	SAME	
12	Extended chords	12. Extended chords and voicings	SAME	Taught with piano voicings, because nobody plays all 7 notes of a 13 chord.

The 12 stages

01

PHASE A · FOUNDATIONS

The keyboard and the 12 notes

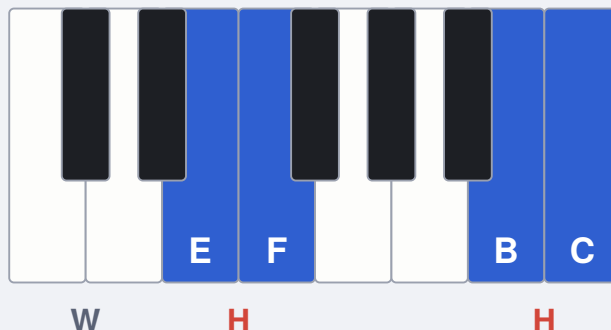
Find any note on the keyboard without thinking.



White keys repeat A–G. **C** sits just left of every group of **two** black keys.

C	C [#] / D ^b	D	D [#] / E ^b	E	F	F [#] / G ^b	G	G [#] / A ^b	A	A [#] / B ^b	B
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The 12 notes. A black key has two names: [#] (sharp) = one key up, ^b (flat) = one key down.



H = half step (next key). **W** = whole step (two half steps). E–F and B–C are half steps with no black key between.

1 Understand

- Seven letter names (A–G) repeat across the whole keyboard.
- Black keys come in groups of 2 and 3. They are your map.
- Sharp ([#]) = one key to the right. Flat (^b) = one key to the left.
- A **half step** is the very next key, black or white. A **whole step** is two half steps. This is the measuring tape for everything that follows.

3 Memorise

- Where C is (left of the two black keys).
- The 12 note names in order, including both names of each black key.

5 Connects to the next stage

Chords are built by counting half steps. Once you can count them, you can build any chord.

2 Practise on the piano

- Play every C on the piano. Then every F. Then every G.
- Name random white keys out loud. Aim for under 2 seconds each.
- Play all 12 keys from C to C and count the half steps.
- Find each black key by both names (C[#] = D^b).

4 Safe to ignore for now

- Reading notes on the staff (treble and bass clef).
- Rhythm notation and time signatures.
- Octave numbers (C4, C5) and rare names like E[#] or C^b.

Ready to move on when

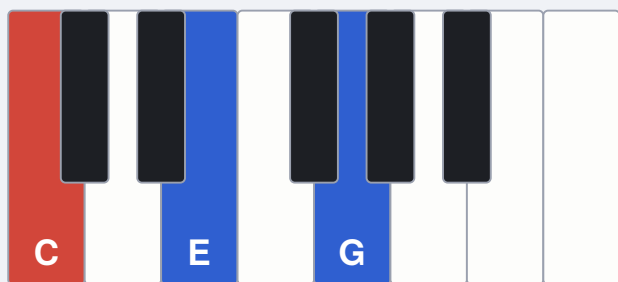
You can find any of the 12 notes instantly and count half steps between two keys.

02

PHASE A · FOUNDATIONS

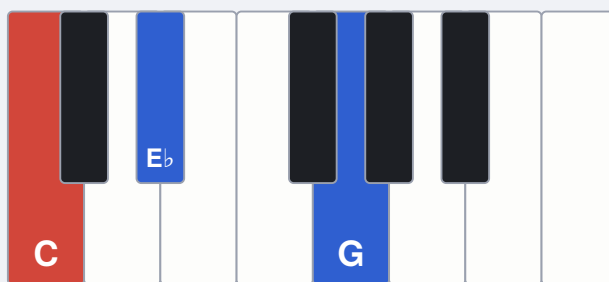
Major and minor chords

Build any major or minor triad by counting.



4 half steps 3

C major (symbol: C). Count 4 + 3 half steps.



3 half steps 4

C minor (symbol: Cm). Count 3 + 4. Only the middle note moves.

Learn them in shape families

	Shape (bottom – middle – top)	Major	Minor
1	All white	C F G	Dm Em Am
2	White – black – white	D E A	Cm Fm Gm
3	Black – white – black	D ^b E ^b A ^b	C [#] m F [#] m G [#] m
4	The odd ones	F [#] B B ^b	E ^b m B ^b m Bm

Chords with the same black/white shape feel the same under your hand. Learn one family at a time, row by row.

1 Understand

- A **triad** is three notes: root, 3rd, 5th.
- Major** = root + 4 half steps + 3 half steps. Sounds bright.
- Minor** = root + 3 half steps + 4 half steps. Sounds darker.
- Chord symbols: a letter alone is major (C). A small m is minor (Cm).

3 Memorise

- The two recipes: **4 + 3** (major) and **3 + 4** (minor).
- Family 1 by feel: C, F, G, Am, Dm, Em.

5 Connects to the next stage

With C, F, G and Am you can already play a huge number of songs. Stage 3 puts them to work.

2 Practise on the piano

- Family 1 first: C, F, G, Dm, Em, Am (all white keys).
- Play each major chord, then lower the middle note: C → Cm, F → Fm.
- Right hand fingers 1–3–5. Left hand fingers 5–3–1.
- Add one shape family per week until you have all 24 chords.

4 Safe to ignore for now

- Correct spelling (E[#] vs F). For now, find the right keys.
- 7th chords, sus chords and other suffixes.
- Diminished and augmented chords (they come in Stage 6 and 10).

Ready to move on when

You can play all 12 major and 12 minor triads, slowly but correctly.

Your first progressions and songs

Accompany a simple song from chord symbols.

C	F	G	C
1 2 3 4	1 2 3 4	1 2 3 4	1 2 3 4

Chord symbols sit above the lyrics or melody. Play the chord where it appears. Hold it until the next symbol.

Pattern	Beat 1	2	3	4
A • Block	LH root + RH chord	hold	hold	hold
B • Pulse	LH root + RH chord	RH chord	RH chord	RH chord
C • Bass + chord	LH root	RH chord	LH root	RH chord

Three accompaniment patterns, easiest first. LH = left hand, RH = right hand.

1 Understand

- A **lead sheet** shows lyrics or melody with chord symbols above.
- You play the chord where the symbol appears and hold it until the next one.
- Most songs use a small family of chords. In C these are C, Dm, Em, F, G and Am.
- Steady rhythm matters more than the right voicing.

2 Memorise

- The six chords of C major: C, Dm, Em, F, G, Am.
- The three accompaniment patterns in the table.

3 Connects to the next stage

You will notice your right hand jumps between chords. Inversions fix that.

4 Practise on the piano

- Loop C – F – G – C, four beats per chord, with a metronome.
- Loop C – G – Am – F the same way.
- Left hand: the root note only. Right hand: the triad.
- Pick one easy song in C or G from a chord-symbol songbook and play it with pattern A, then B, then C.

5 Safe to ignore for now

- Why these chords belong together (Stage 6 explains it).
- Playing the melody at the same time.
- Complex rhythms and syncopation.

Ready to move on when

You can play one song start to finish in steady time without stopping.

04

PHASE B · PLAYING WITH CHORDS

Inversions

Change chords with minimal hand movement.



Root position

C–E–G (root at the bottom)



1st inversion

E–G–C (3rd at the bottom)

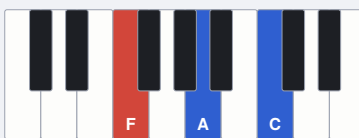


2nd inversion

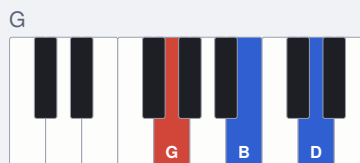
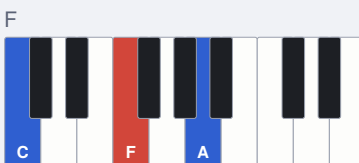
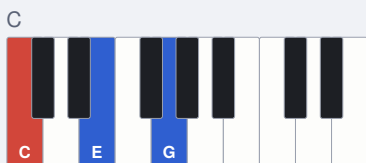
G–C–E (5th at the bottom)

Why it matters: C – F – G

JUMPY



SMOOTH



C

F/C (2nd inv.)

G/B (1st inv.)

Same three chords. Smooth version: keep shared notes, move the others to the nearest key. Your hand barely moves.

1 Understand

- An inversion uses the same notes in a different order.
- **Root position:** root at the bottom. **1st inversion:** 3rd at the bottom. **2nd inversion:** 5th at the bottom.
- The chord name does not change. It is still C.
- A slash chord like **C/E** means: C chord, E in the bass.

3 Memorise

- The rule: **keep shared notes, move the others to the nearest key.**
- The smooth voicings of C – F – G – Am in C major.

5 Connects to the next stage

Now you can play smoothly. Next you learn *why* C, F, G and Am belong together: the major scale.

2 Practise on the piano

- Play C in all three positions, up and down the keyboard.
- Do the same for F, G and Am.
- Play C – F/C – G/B – C (the smooth row) until it feels automatic.
- Go back to your Stage 3 song and use the nearest inversion for each chord.

4 Safe to ignore for now

- Classical inversion labels (6, 6/4).
- 3rd inversions (they need four notes, see Stage 11).

Ready to move on when

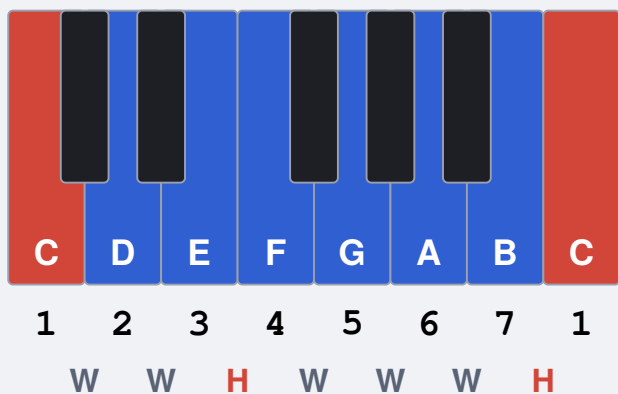
You can loop C – G – Am – F with your right hand staying in one place.

05

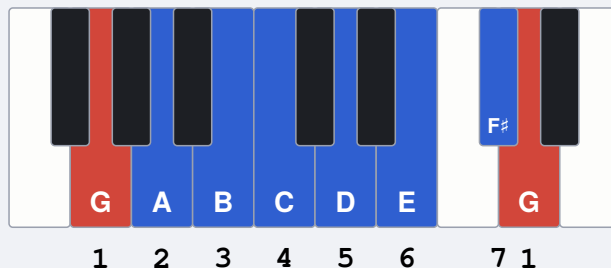
PHASE C · UNDERSTANDING KEYS

The major scale and scale degrees

Understand what a key is.



C major scale. Pattern **W W H W W W H**. Numbers below = scale degrees.



G major: same pattern from G. The pattern forces one black key: **F#**.

1 Understand

- Every major scale uses the same step pattern: **W W H W W W H**.
- A **key** is the scale a song is built on. The first note is **home** (the tonic).
- Each scale note gets a number from 1 to 7. These **scale degrees** work in every key.
- Starting the pattern on G forces F#. That is why G major has one sharp.

3 Memorise

- The pattern **W W H W W W H**.
- Scales of C, G, D and F.

5 Connects to the next stage

Build a triad on each of the 7 scale notes and you get the chords of the key.

2 Practise on the piano

- C major and G major, hands separately, one octave.
- Fingering (C, G, D): RH 1-2-3-1-2-3-4-5, LH 5-4-3-2-1-3-2-1.
- F major: RH 1-2-3-4-1-2-3-4 (thumb goes under after B $\flat$).
- Say the numbers while you play. Then jump: "play 4", "play 5", "play 1".

4 Safe to ignore for now

- Modes (Dorian, Lydian ...).
- Harmonic and melodic minor scales.
- Playing scales fast or hands together.

Ready to move on when

You can build the major scale from any note using the step pattern.

Diatonic chords and Roman numerals

Know which chords belong to a key and name them by number.

Top (5th)	G	A	B	C	D	E	F
Middle (3rd)	E	F	G	A	B	C	D
Root	C	D	E	F	G	A	B
Chord	C	Dm	Em	F	G	Am	Bdim
Numeral	I	ii	iii	IV	V	vi	vii°

Take every other scale note, starting on each degree. Only white keys in C. **UPPERCASE** = major, **lowercase** = minor, ° = diminished.

Key	I	ii	iii	IV	V	vi	vii°
C major	C	Dm	Em	F	G	Am	Bdim
G major	G	Am	Bm	C	D	Em	F#dim
F major	F	Gm	Am	Bb	C	Dm	Edim
D major	D	Em	F#m	G	A	Bm	C#dim

The pattern is the same in every key: **major minor minor major major minor diminished**. All 12 keys come in Stage 8.

1 Understand

- Stack every other note of the scale and you get 7 chords. These are the **diatonic chords** of the key.
- Roman numerals name each chord by its position: I, ii, iii, IV, V, vi, vii°.
- Uppercase** = major. **Lowercase** = minor. ° = diminished.
- Numbers let you think in any key: "I – IV – V" is C–F–G in C, and G–C–D in G.

3 Memorise

- The pattern: I ii iii IV V vi vii°.
- I, IV and V are the three major chords. vi is the minor one you will meet most.

5 Connects to the next stage

A chord progression is just a pattern of numerals. Stage 7 gives you the most common ones.

2 Practise on the piano

- Play the 7 chords up the scale in C, G, F and D. Say the numeral aloud.
- Take your Stage 3 song and write the numerals under the chords.
- Call out a random numeral in a key and play it ("G major, vi" → Em).

4 Safe to ignore for now

- How to use vii° (rare in pop music).
- Chords from outside the key (borrowed chords, secondary dominants).

Ready to move on when

You can name the 7 chords of C, G, F and D without looking.

07

PHASE C · UNDERSTANDING KEYS

Common chord progressions

Recognise the patterns that most songs are made of.

Progression	in C	in G	in F	in D
I – IV – V – I The basic family. Folk, rock 'n' roll, children's songs.	C – F – G – C	G – C – D – G	F – B $\flat$ – C – F	D – G – A – D
I – V – vi – IV The classic pop loop.	C – G – Am – F	G – D – Em – C	F – C – Dm – B $\flat$	D – A – Bm – G
vi – IV – I – V Same four chords, starting on the minor. Sounds sadder.	Am – F – C – G	Em – C – G – D	Dm – B $\flat$ – F – C	Bm – G – D – A
I – vi – IV – V The '50s ballad loop.	C – Am – F – G	G – Em – C – D	F – Dm – B $\flat$ – C	D – Bm – G – A
ii – V – I The jazz standard move. Later with 7th chords.	Dm – G – C	Am – D – G	Gm – C – F	Em – A – D

1 Understand

- A handful of numeral patterns turn up in a very large number of songs.
- Once you know the pattern, you can play it in any key you know.
- The V chord pulls back to I. Listen for that “coming home” feeling.

3 Memorise

- The five progressions as **numerals**, not as chord names.

5 Connects to the next stage

To play these patterns in every key you need all 12 keys. The Circle of Fifths organises them.

2 Practise on the piano

- Each progression in C, then G, then F. Use smooth inversions from Stage 4.
- Accompaniment pattern B or C, with a metronome.
- Listen to songs you like and try to hear when the music returns to I.
- Look up chord charts of songs you know and find these patterns in them.

4 Safe to ignore for now

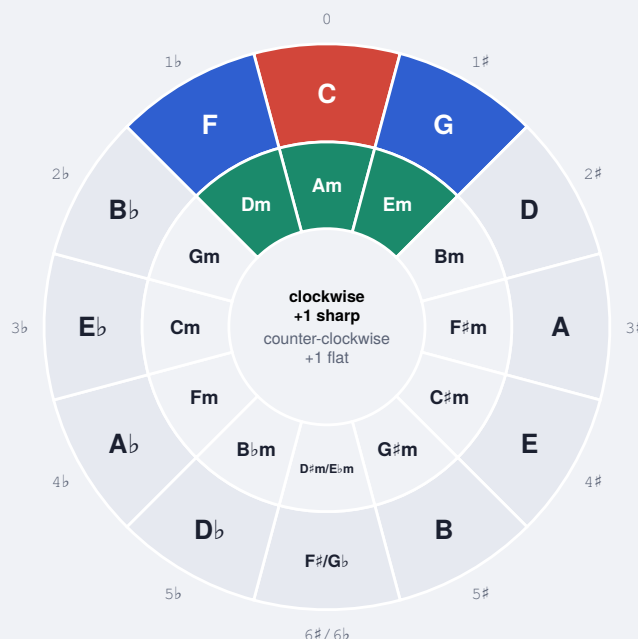
- Jazz substitutions.
- Key changes within a song.
- Long chord charts with many unusual chords.

Ready to move on when

You can play I – V – vi – IV in C, G and F from memory.

The Circle of Fifths and all 12 keys

Organise all keys on one map.



Key of C: **C** (I) with its neighbours **F** (IV) and **G** (V). Inner ring: **Dm, Am, Em** (ii, vi, iii). Six of the seven chords sit in one slice.

Order of sharps	F#	C#	G#	D#	A#	E#	B#	"Father Charles Goes Down And Ends Battle"
Order of flats	Bb	Eb	Ab	Db	Gb	Cb	Fb	The same letters backwards ("BEAD" + G C F)

Shortcut sharps: last sharp + one half step up = key name (F#, C# → D major). Shortcut flats: second-to-last flat = key name (Bb, Eb, Ab → Eb major). F major (1 flat) you just memorise.

1 Understand

- Going **clockwise**, each key is a 5th higher and adds one sharp.
- Going **counter-clockwise**, each key adds one flat.
- Neighbours are closely related. The key's I, IV and V sit side by side.
- The inner ring shows the **relative minor** of each key. It shares the same key signature.
- To transpose a song, move every chord the same number of steps around the circle.

3 Memorise

- The circle order: C G D A E B F# / Db Ab Eb Bb F.
- How many sharps or flats each key has.
- The order of sharps (F C G D A E B) and flats (B E A D G C F).

5 Connects to the next stage

The inner ring is the door to minor keys.

2 Practise on the piano

- Add new keys in circle order: C → G and F → D and Bb → A and Eb → E and Ab → the rest.
- For each new key: scale, the 7 diatonic chords, and I – IV – V – I with inversions.
- Draw the circle from memory once a week.
- Transpose your favourite progression into three keys.

4 Safe to ignore for now

- Keys with 7 sharps or flats (C#, Cb). Use Db and B instead.
- Writing key signatures on a staff.

Ready to move on when

Given any key, you can name its sharps/flats and its I, IV, V.

09

PHASE C · UNDERSTANDING KEYS

Minor keys

Play and recognise songs in minor.

Key	i	ii°	III	iv	v / V	VI	VII
A minor	Am	Bdim	C	Dm	Em / E	F	G
E minor	Em	F#dim	G	Am	Bm / B	C	D
D minor	Dm	Edim	F	Gm	Am / A	Bb	C

A minor uses the same chords as C major, starting from Am. Songs in minor often swap the minor v for a **major V** (E instead of Em in A minor). That gives a stronger pull home.

1 Understand

- Every major key has a **relative minor**. It starts on degree 6 (vi).
- Relative keys share all notes and chords. Only “home” is different.
- In a minor key the numerals start from the minor chord: i ii° III iv v VI VII.
- A song with no sharps or flats that feels sad and ends on Am is in A minor, not C major.

3 Memorise

- Relative pairs: C/Am, G/Em, F/Dm, D/Bm, Bb/Gm.
- In minor, the V is often major.

5 Connects to the next stage

You now know the chord families of all keys. Next you add colour to the chords.

2 Practise on the piano

- In A minor: Am – Dm – E – Am (i – iv – V – i).
- In A minor: Am – F – C – G (i – VI – III – VII).
- Repeat in E minor and D minor.

4 Safe to ignore for now

- Harmonic and melodic minor scales in detail.
- Modes.

Ready to move on when

You can tell whether a simple song is in a major key or its relative minor.

10

PHASE D · RICHER HARMONY

More chord symbols: sus, add9, 6, slash chords

Read the extra letters in a chord chart.

Symbol	Change	Formula	In C
Csus2	3rd → 2nd	1 – 2 – 5	C D G
Csus4	3rd → 4th	1 – 4 – 5	C F G
Cadd9	add the 9th (= 2nd, one octave up)	1 – 3 – 5 – 9	C E G D
C6	add the 6th	1 – 3 – 5 – 6	C E G A
C5	no 3rd (“power chord”)	1 – 5	C G
Cdim	minor 3rd and flat 5th	1 – b3 – b5	C Eb Gb
Caug · C+	raise the 5th	1 – 3 – #5	C E G#
C/E	C chord, E in the bass	slash = bass note	LH E, RH C E G

Each suffix changes or adds one note. The letter before the suffix is always the root.

1 Understand

- A suffix after the letter changes or adds one note. The letter is still the root.
- sus chords replace the 3rd. They sound open and unresolved.
- add9 and 6 add colour to a normal triad.
- The note after a slash is the bass note (your left hand).

3 Memorise

- What sus2, sus4, add9, 6 and a slash do.

2 Practise on the piano

- Csus4 → C, Gsus4 → G. Hear the tension resolve.
- Replace some chords in a progression with add9 versions (Cadd9, Fadd9).
- Play slash chords from a chart: left hand the bass note, right hand the chord.

4 Safe to ignore for now

- 9, 11 and 13 chords (Stage 12).
- Rare symbols like 7#9 or 7b13.

5 Connects to the next stage

The most important added note is the 7th. It gets its own stage.

Ready to move on when

You can read a chart with sus, add9 and slash chords without stopping.

11

PHASE D · RICHER HARMONY

Seventh chords

Understand the five main 7th chords.



Cmaj7 · 1 3 5 7
soft, dreamy



C7 · 1 3 5 b7
bluesy, wants to move



Cm7 · 1 b3 5 b7
mellow minor



Cm7b5 (Cø7) · 1 b3 b5 b7
dark, unstable



Cdim7 (C°7) · 1 b3 b5 bb7
tense (Bbb = the A key)

"7" alone

means the flat 7th (Bb in C). This is the *dominant* 7th.

"maj"

changes only the 7th: the natural 7th (B in C).

"m"

changes only the 3rd: the minor 3rd (Eb in C).

The 7th chords of C major: **Cmaj7** **Dm7** **Em7** **Fmaj7** **G7** **Am7** **Bm7b5**. The V7 (G7) is the only "7" chord in the key.

1 Understand

- A 7th chord is a triad plus one more note: the 7th.
- Three rules explain most symbols: "7" = flat 7th, "maj" changes the 7th, "m" changes the 3rd.
- V7 has a strong pull back to I (G7 → C).
- ii7 – V7 – Imaj7 is the core of jazz harmony (Dm7 – G7 – Cmaj7).

3 Memorise

- The formulas of maj7, 7, m7, m7b5 and dim7.
- The 7th-chord pattern of a major key: Imaj7 ii7 iii7 IVmaj7 V7 vi7 viiø7.

5 Connects to the next stage

Extended chords are 7th chords with even more notes stacked on top.

2 Practise on the piano

- On one root, play C → Cmaj7 → C7 → Cm7. Hear each change.
- ii7 – V7 – Imaj7 in C, F and Bb.
- Four notes means four positions. Practise the 3rd inversion (7th at the bottom).
- Simple voicing: LH root, RH the other three notes.

4 Safe to ignore for now

- mMaj7 and aug7 (rare; look them up when they appear).
- Altered dominants (7b9, 7#9).

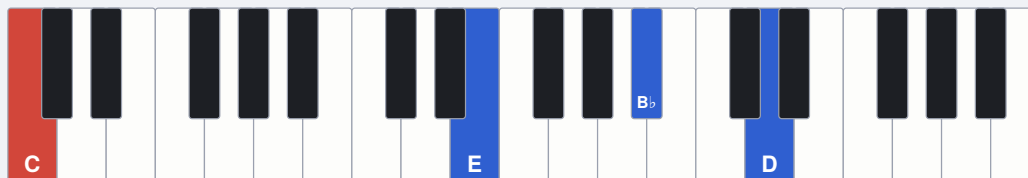
Ready to move on when

You can play Dm7 – G7 – Cmaj7 smoothly and name each note.

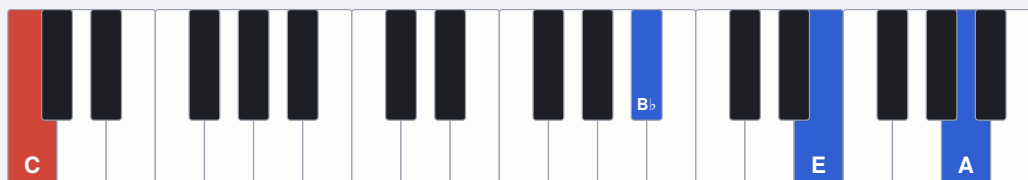
Extended chords and voicings

Play 9, 11 and 13 chords the way pianists really do.

Number	Same note as	Chord	Full formula	What piano players usually leave out
9	2	C9	1 3 5 $\flat$ 7 9	the 5th
11	4	C11	1 3 5 $\flat$ 7 9 11	the 3rd (it clashes with the 11)
13	6	C13	1 3 5 $\flat$ 7 9 11 13	the 5th, 9th and 11th

C9 · LH: C · RH: E B $\flat$ D (3 $\flat$ 7 9). The 5th is left out.

Cmaj9 · LH: C · RH: E G B D (3 5 7 9)

C13 · LH: C · RH: B $\flat$ E A ($\flat$ 7 3 13). The 9th and 11th are left out.

1 Understand

- 9, 11 and 13 continue the stack of 3rds above the 7th.
- 9 = the 2nd, 11 = the 4th, 13 = the 6th, just one octave higher.
- A number above 7 implies the 7th is also there (C9 includes B $\flat$).
- You rarely play every note. Pianists leave out the 5th and other notes that clash.

3 Memorise

- 9 = 2, 11 = 4, 13 = 6.
- What to leave out: the 5th almost always.

5 Connects to the next stage

From here, most learning happens through songs. Every new chart teaches you a new chord.

2 Practise on the piano

- C9, Cmaj9 and C13 with the voicings shown above.
- Dm9 – G13 – Cmaj9 as a richer ii – V – I.
- Take a song you know and replace plain chords with 7ths and 9ths.

4 Safe to ignore for now

- Upper-structure triads and polychords.
- Full theory of chord tensions. Learn by ear and by chart.

Ready to move on when

You can read a lead sheet with 7th and 9th chords and play it in time.

The song thread

Songs are not the final stage. They run alongside everything from Stage 3 on.

Stages 3–4

Songs with 3–4 chords in C or G. Block chords, then simple patterns.

Stages 8–9

Transpose songs to a comfortable singing key. Add songs in minor.

Stages 5–7

Write numerals under every chart. Play the same song in two keys.

Stages 10–12

Charts with sus, add9 and 7th chords. Try broken chords and arpeggios.

A daily practice session

Minutes	Block	Example (while in Stage 7)
5	Warm-up · scale of the current key	F major, hands separately
5	Chord drill · random chords from earlier stages	Call out “E $\flat$ ”, “F $\sharp$ m”, “G/B” and play them
10	New concept · the current stage	I – V – vi – IV in F with smooth inversions
10	Song · apply it to real music	Play a song from a chord chart, pattern C

About 30 minutes. Short daily sessions work better than one long session per week.

Symbols used: $\sharp$ sharp · $\flat$ flat · $^\circ$ diminished · $\emptyset$ half-diminished · W whole step · H half step · LH/RH left/right hand.